

Laryngitis

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Laryngitis is inflammation of the voice box (larynx).

- A virus is usually what causes the inflammation. Bacterial infection following a viral illness is a less common cause.
- Acute laryngitis lasts between 1 and 3 weeks. Long-term (chronic) laryngitis lasts longer than 3 weeks.
- Typical symptoms include hoarseness and loss of voice.
- The diagnosis is based on symptoms and changes of the voice.
- Usually, resting the voice and avoiding any irritants are adequate treatment.

Causes of Laryngitis

The **most common cause** of short-lived (acute, lasting less than 3 weeks) laryngitis is

- Viral infection of the upper airways, such as the [common cold](#)

Laryngitis also may accompany [bronchitis](#) or any other inflammation or infection of the upper airways. Excessive use of the voice, allergies, inhalation of certain medications, or irritants such as cigarette smoke can cause acute or persistent (chronic) laryngitis. Bacterial infections of the larynx are extremely rare.

Chronic laryngitis, in which symptoms last longer than 3 weeks, also may be caused by [gastroesophageal reflux](#) or, less commonly, by lingering bronchitis. People with [bulimia](#) who vomit frequently may develop laryngitis.

Symptoms of Laryngitis

Symptoms of laryngitis are a persistent change of voice, such as hoarseness or a decrease in volume, or even loss of voice that develops within hours to a day or so. The throat may tickle or feel raw, and a person may have a constant urge to clear the throat.

Symptoms vary with the severity of the inflammation. Fever, a general feeling of illness (malaise), difficulty in swallowing, and a sore throat may occur in severe infections.

Diagnosis of Laryngitis

- A doctor's evaluation
- Sometimes inspection of the larynx with a mirror or a viewing tube
- Sometimes evaluation for cancer

The diagnosis of laryngitis is usually based on the typical symptoms and voice changes.

In chronic laryngitis, the doctor looks down the throat with a mirror or a thin, flexible viewing tube, which shows some reddening and sometimes some swelling of the lining of the larynx.

Because cancer of the larynx may cause hoarseness, a person whose symptoms persist more than a few weeks should be evaluated for [laryngeal cancer](#). If the doctor finds a thin layer of dead tissue covering the mucous membrane, diphtheria is suspected.

Treatment of Laryngitis

- Resting the voice, cough suppressants, extra fluids, and steam
- Treatment of the cause

Treatment of viral laryngitis depends on the symptoms. Resting the voice (by not speaking), taking cough suppressants, drinking extra fluids, and inhaling steam relieve symptoms and help healing. Whispering, however, may irritate the larynx even more. Stopping smoking and treating bronchitis, if present, may alleviate laryngitis.

An antibiotic is given only for infection caused by bacteria.

Depending on the possible cause, specific treatments to control gastroesophageal reflux or medication-induced laryngitis may be helpful.



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